

Spoken English Class Gorakhpur

Language of Prosperity



Every morning, 17-year-old Surendra Vishwakarma travels 45 km from Parsauni village to reach Gorakhpur, first on cycle and then on an overloaded auto. He does it to learn English, a passport to a Merchant Navy course. He is not the only explorer of his dreams. Niharika Srivastava, 22, who graduated in political science from Gorakhpur University, realised she couldn't do

"As an engineer, I want to invent a low-cost car for rural roads. But for that, I have to be fluent in English first."

LAKSHMAN GUPTA
Student, Veta English Institute

DREAM
To compete with the urban youth in landing jobs

much with it unless she learnt English. It's the same with Lakshman Gupta, 19, who dreams of becoming Ratan Tata one day. The only thing that stops this engineering aspirant is his English-speaking skills, which he is now honing at the Veta English Institute. Its director Puneet Agarwal, 28, says the idea was to teach English to youngsters who were losing out to those from English medium schools. "I want to create a generation which can be part of an economic revolution," he says. Today, Gorakhpur has three BPO and call centre training institutes and 185 English-speaking training centres. At Agarwal's institute, there are about 175 students, all in the age group of 17-30. Over 30 per cent are girls. They are trying to overcome what Ajay Ratnani, 30, head of a call centre training institute, calls the MTI (Mother Tongue Influence). "We train rural youth to have a dream and follow it too. One way of doing it is to help them overcome the MTL." **by Farzand Ahmed**

Persian and Arabic Language Students Bhopal

Past Forward

After a tough semester examinations, a classroom would be the last thing on a student's agenda. Unless it is the near-full Persian language class at Maharani Laxmibai Girls' College. "It's the *hukumati zubaan* of Bhopal," says 23-year-old Shazia Naqvi. For many of the girls, knowledge of

Persian and Arabic could be handy for a career in academics or diplomacy. Or even to keep Unani medicine alive. Asks the tall, hijab-clad, Sama Javed, 22, who comes from a family of academics, "Who is going to be able to refer to historically-relevant texts in these languages, which are important in understanding our history?" She's done her homework. Arabic is the second most popular language for students at Hyderabad's Indian Institute of Foreign Languages. It would also help if other communities learnt it, she says. "If they knew our texts, they would understand Islam better."

by Ambresh Mishra

DREAM
To show that ancient languages have modern-day relevance

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"Everyone should learn Arabic and Persian to understand Islam and reduce communalism."

SAMA JAVED Student,
Maharani Laxmibai Girls' College